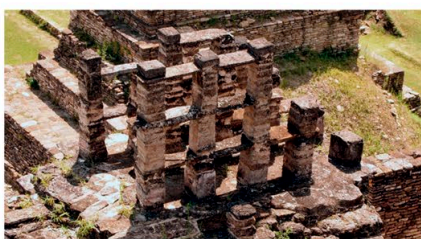
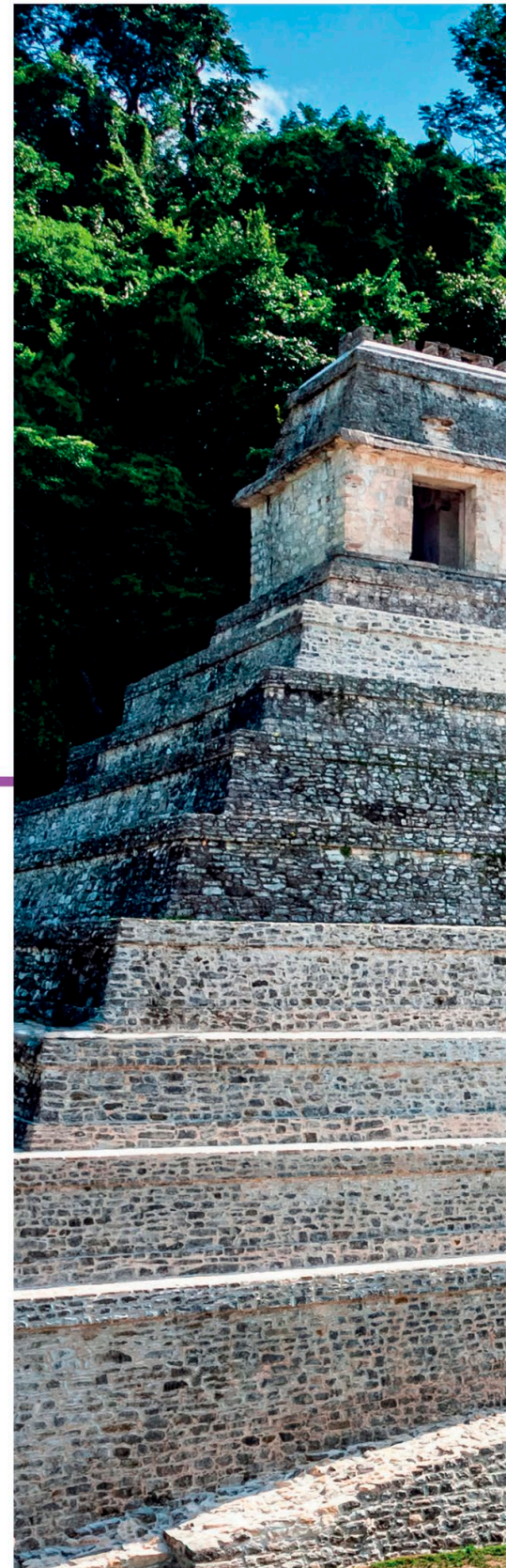


250–900 CE

THE CLASSIC MAYA CIVILIZATION

A **sophisticated civilization** of pre-Columbian Mesoamerica developed in the area that today encompasses southern Mexico, Guatemala, Belize, El Salvador, and Honduras. The indigenous peoples, now known as the Maya, began to form complex societies from about 2000 BCE, settling in cities by about 750 BCE. Their distinctive culture continued to flourish in the Classic Period (250–900 CE), which was marked by the introduction of their calendar, known as the Long Count calendar. At this time, the Maya civilization consisted of a network of autonomous city-states linked by trade,

or by rivalry for influence in the region. Urban centres including Tikal, Calakmul, Copán, Palenque, and Yaxchilan were ruled over by dynasties of “divine kings” – spiritual as well as political and military leaders – and an increasingly strong aristocracy. Palaces, monuments, and pyramidal temples were prominent in Classic Maya society; other buildings included observatories and courts for ceremonial ball games. Development of a writing system produced an educated class among which astronomy and mathematics flourished and whose patronage fostered a golden age of arts and crafts.



KEY MOMENTS

250–900 CE Rise of Tikal and Calakmul

The Maya civilization of the Classic Period was marked by the rise of powerful city-states. Foremost among these were the rival cities of Tikal and Calakmul (*left*), which fought for dominance throughout the period.

250 CE Maya script

By around 250 CE, the Maya had developed a writing system that used symbols to represent words and syllables. The symbols, or glyphs, were arranged in blocks to form words and phrases; they were written on a form of paper made from tree bark or inscribed on stone or ceramic artefacts (*left*).

c. 750–900 CE Classic Maya collapse

The Classic Maya city-states of the southern lowlands began to decline for reasons that remain a mystery. By about 900 CE, they were largely abandoned (*left*), and the centre of the Postclassic Maya civilization shifted north to cities including Chichen Itza.